

Saudi Arabia: Houthi strikes lift oil risks, not full war

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【メール原文】

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Quick take

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Houthi strikes lift oil risks without triggering full war

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

What Happened

On 8 September, Yemen's Houthis launched drone and missile attacks on multiple sites in southern Saudi Arabia. The strikes ignited fires and temporarily suspended operations at some energy facilities, including sites near Jizan. Saudi officials reported the attacks wounded 73 people. Saudi Arabia responded with attacks in Yemen, escalating the conflict and increasing risks to Red Sea trade routes.

Our Take

A simmering Saudi-Houthi conflict remains the basecase for 2026 (55% odds). The latest escalation between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis remains below the threshold of all-out war. Riyadh will likely continue to calibrate its response to avoid a major reentry into Yemen while restoring deterrence, relying on airstrikes, intelligence support, and greater use of Yemeni government-aligned forces for ground pressure (see: [Intensifying Saudi-Houthi conflict still likely to fall short of all-out war](#), 1 September 2026). Saudi Foreign Minister Prince Faisal bin Farhan's public emphasis on the continued possibility of diplomacy also underscores Riyadh's incentive to preserve an off-ramp even as the kingdom retaliates.

The Houthi response also remains short of causing serious damage to Saudi energy infrastructure and export capacity, reflecting the group's desire to avoid pushing Saudi Arabia toward all-out war. Nonetheless, miscalculations could still happen and drive a more intense conflict.

A compromise remains unlikely this year (10% odds). Saudi Arabia and the Houthis both prefer to reach a compromise while using force to gain leverage. However, a compromise remains unlikely in 2026 because Riyadh continues to resist the Houthis' financial and operational demands.

The most credible path to an all-out war scenario (35% odds) is not a gradual tit-for-tat escalation. Rather, it is a sharper shift, such as sustained strikes that materially damage Saudi energy infrastructure or a more aggressive Houthi effort to threaten traffic through Bab al-Mandeb, where Saudi reliance has grown as exports reroute from the Gulf. In that scenario, energy markets would likely

reprice quickly because disruption in the Bab al-Mandeb would add to existing regional transit constraints and increase the risk of broader supply disruptions.

Energy supply risks will remain real but skew toward episodic disruption rather than sustained outages. Saudi Arabia's Energy Ministry said the strikes temporarily suspended operations at some southern oil facilities and utilities, suggesting short-term interruptions rather than structural damage in most cases. The Jizan complex will remain a recurring vulnerability because of its proximity to Yemen and its role in Saudi Red Sea energy logistics. That exposure will increase the risk of stop-start downtime and intermittent export constraints.

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